

In the genes

Genes are instructions that build your body and tell it how to work. Your genes control many of the things that make you unique, like the colour of your eyes or how tall you'll be.



This girl has a gene that allows her to roll up her tongue. The boy doesn't have the gene, so he can't do it.



Hands on

Look in a mirror and see if you can roll your tongue. Don't cheat by squeezing it with your lips. Test your family to see who has the gene.

DNA

Your genes are stored in a chemical called DNA, which looks like a twisted ladder with four different types of rung. The rungs make up a four-letter alphabet that spells out your genes, like letters in a book.



In the family

Your genes came from your parents. Half come from your mother and half come from your father. If you look like your parents, it's because you share the same genes.

DNA can split and copy itself.



Learning to ride a bike changes your brain and your body.

Changing body

Genes don't control everything – experience also shapes you.

If you exercise a lot, for instance, your body gets stronger.

About 30,000 specific genes.